



BRC Rope Tow Activity Plan

Use of the Rope Tow at the Bogong Rover Chalet

Purpose

This document serves to define the safe practices and further information regarding the “Nutcracker” style Rope Tow installed at the Bogong Rover Chalet. It covers the facilities available, safety procedures, training requirements and framework, compliance to regulatory standards.

Background

The Bogong Rover Chalet, located on the Bogong High Plains road is a remote backcountry chalet. It is accessible, in winter, by an 11km relatively flat ski from Falls Creek via Langfords Gap and Langfords West aqueduct.

Additional information surrounding the BRC and its operations can be found on the BRC Activity Plans and website.

Participants are assumed to have sufficient fitness and ability to ski however, the participants are not assumed to have any particular level of ski ability including downhill ability.

The BRC is equipped with an approximately 200m rope tow that provides elevated access to the immediate slopes surrounding the chalet. The rope tow may also be used by day touring parties as a starting point to gain height for accessing the wider Bogong High Plains.

Rope Tow Facility

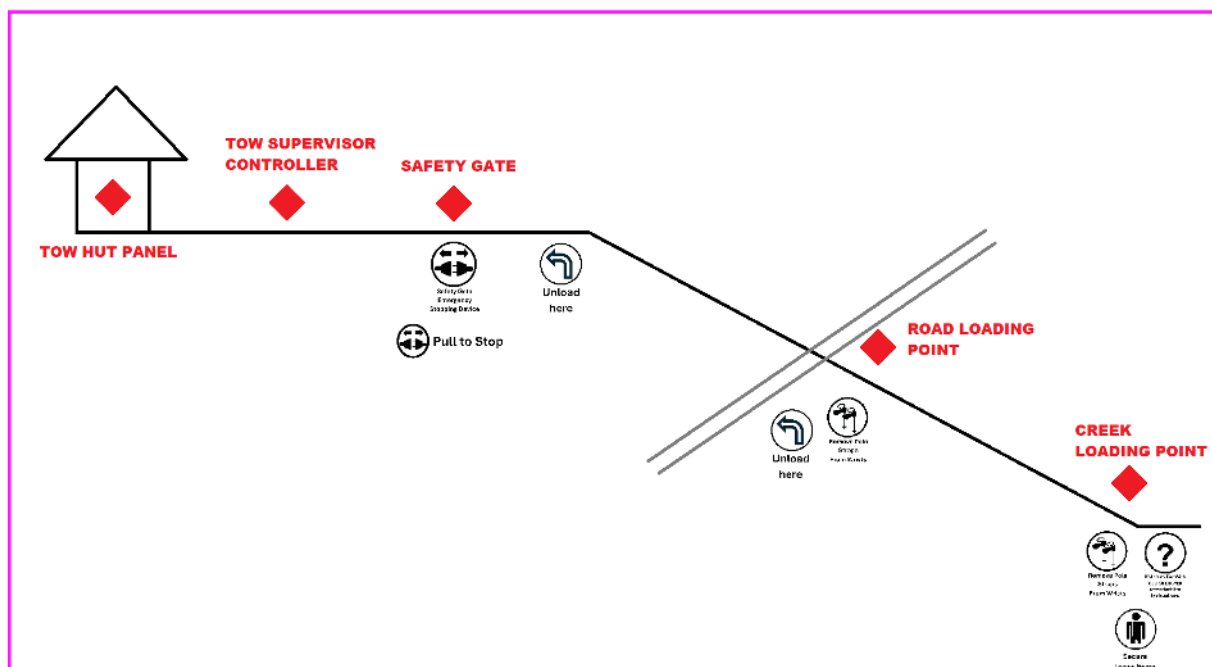
The rope tow is a single rope loop driven from a drive wheel at the top and returned via a return wheel at the bottom. The rope loop is vertically aligned with a lower haul rope supported by sheaves on poles and an upper return rope also supported by return sheaves on the same poles.

There are 2 tow loading stations. The first station, called the Creek Loading Station, is located at the bottom of the slope just prior to the creek crossing. The second loading station, called the Road Loading Point, is located on the road that runs past the chalet. The Road Loading Point may also be used as an unloading station. There is a top unloading station at the top of the slope, prior to the Safety Gate.

The drive wheel is turned by a worm gear connected to a diesel-powered motor. The drive wheel and motor are housed in a tow shed at the top of the slope above the top unloading station. There is a safety gate between the top unloading station and the tow shed that shuts down the rope tow prior to a user encountering the tow shed.

Rope tow users wear a hip belt. A clamping device, referred to as a nutcracker, on the hip belt is used to clamp the haul rope using hand pressure on the nutcracker applied by the user. While the rope is clamped, the rope will drag the user, standing on their skis or snowboard, up the hill along the tow line. When the user releases the hand pressure on the nutcracker, the user will detach from the rope. The user can thus detach at any point on the rope line, e.g. at the unloading station or if the user encounters an obstacle. If the user falls, they will naturally release the nutcracker and detach from the rope, preventing the user from being dragged. The nutcracker is designed to roll over the sheaves without disengaging the rope. The hands of the user on the nutcracker are kept clear of the sheaves.

Safety stops are provided for riders at each of the lower station, mid station and top station. There is a line of sight from the lower station all the way along the rope line, up to approximately the upper 20 metres before the top station. An attendant at the top station has line of sight down the rope line for approximately 40 metres. There is thus an overlap between the lines of sight from bottom up and top down. There are a further 2 safety stop systems fitted, one on a controller with a long wire for the Tow Supervisor to activate, and one fitted directly onto the control panel for usage where required for maintenance purposes.



When determined to be required by the Designated Tow Operator, the Road Loading Point can be temporarily placed out of service to reduce staffing requirements. In such case, unloading signage will be removed and the station unstaffed, however the emergency stop system will remain operational and in place.

The heights of the drag rope sheaves are adjustable to account for varying snow depths.

The skill level required to safely use the rope tow is not high and most users become safe and competent within a few runs. Similarly, the safety aspects are not arduous and most trained users can quickly become trained as a Tow Supervisor and monitor new participants with loading, unloading and recognising when intervention is required through the use of the e-stops. Many of the regular participants at the BRC have 5+ years of experience of rope tow use including teaching and supervising first-time users.

Beginning in the 2024 season, the BCMG has appointed at least one participant for each week as a Tow Leader, since 2026 this has become the role of a single person. This person is selected as being someone who is known from past winter party experience as having sufficient experience in riding the tow, including the safety procedures and use of the safety gate.

The Tow Leader's role is to:

- Assess and document the competencies of participants in their winter party regarding tow usage.
- Evaluate participants within the BRC Rope Tow Training Program (those competent to assist others and knowledgeable about safety procedures vs. those who are not).
- Making sure the tow is being run in accordance with our process and procedures.

Safety Standards for Rope Tows

Australian Standard AS 4722:2018 is the Australian Standard applicable to rope tows. AS 4722:2018 makes reference to Canadian Standard CSA Z98:14 which is a 2014 standard that has now been superseded by CSA Z98:24. The rope tow at the BRC is intended to be operated in accordance with CSA Z98:24 to our best endeavours. Any known departures from the standard will be put in writing, with justification, for review by the relevant risk assessment personnel.

Noteworthy features of CSA Z98:14 include:

- The requirement for safety stops at each loading and unloading station
- The requirement for attendants at loading stations
- Regulation of Training logs
- Regulation of Maintenance logs
- Regulation of Safety check logs

Terrain

The terrain accessible by the rope tope includes a generally cleared area above the BRC and aqueduct road with few trees, rocks and obstacles. The area directly above the BRC is referred to as the Home Slope and provides an easier gradient. The area adjacent to the rope tow is referred to as the Tow Slope and provides a more challenging gradient.

From the Home Slope, skiers are funnelled to the clear path through the trees near the Chalet. From the Tow Slope, skiers are funnelled to the clear path through the trees near the Road Loading Point.

2026 Publication, reviewed 20/04/2026.

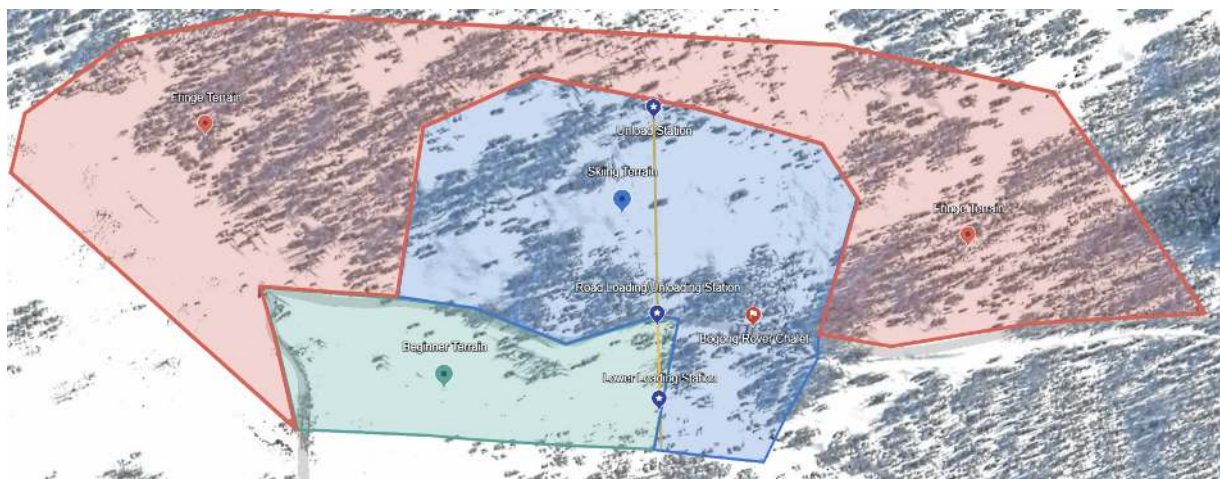
To the west of the tow rope line there are three meadows, named Meadow 1, Meadow 2, Meadow 3. These meadows provide similar gradients and difficulty to the Home Slope and are thus accessible for beginner skiers.

Below the road adjacent the tow line is the nursery slope that provides easier skiing as well as access to the bottom loading station.

There is accessible terrain east of the Home Slope that provides tree skiing to the road and then a mixture of clear and tree skiing below the road to the creek. Access back to the chalet is by climbing the hill to the road or by climbing the creek line to the bottom loading station.

Beyond these borders participants will be considered to be ski touring and the usual ski touring requirements will apply.

A map of the terrain is available at both in this document, on display in the BRC and also the tow hut - will be specifically referenced during the rope tow usage briefing during winter parties.



The sections marked in green on this map are considered “easier” skiing and the sections marked in blue are considered “more challenging”. The sections marked in red are also considered “more challenging”, but Tow Operators must ensure that when skiing in this Fringe Terrain is occurring, there is a minimum of 4 tow riders and the buddy system is being used. The above further applies to areas outside the bounds of the activity area, marked colourless, where a Trip Intention Form must also be completed.

Operation

Prior to the first operation of the rope tow on any winter party, a rope tow safety briefing must be conducted in the presence of the entire party. The briefing must reference the Rope Tow Training Program document. The briefing must cover:

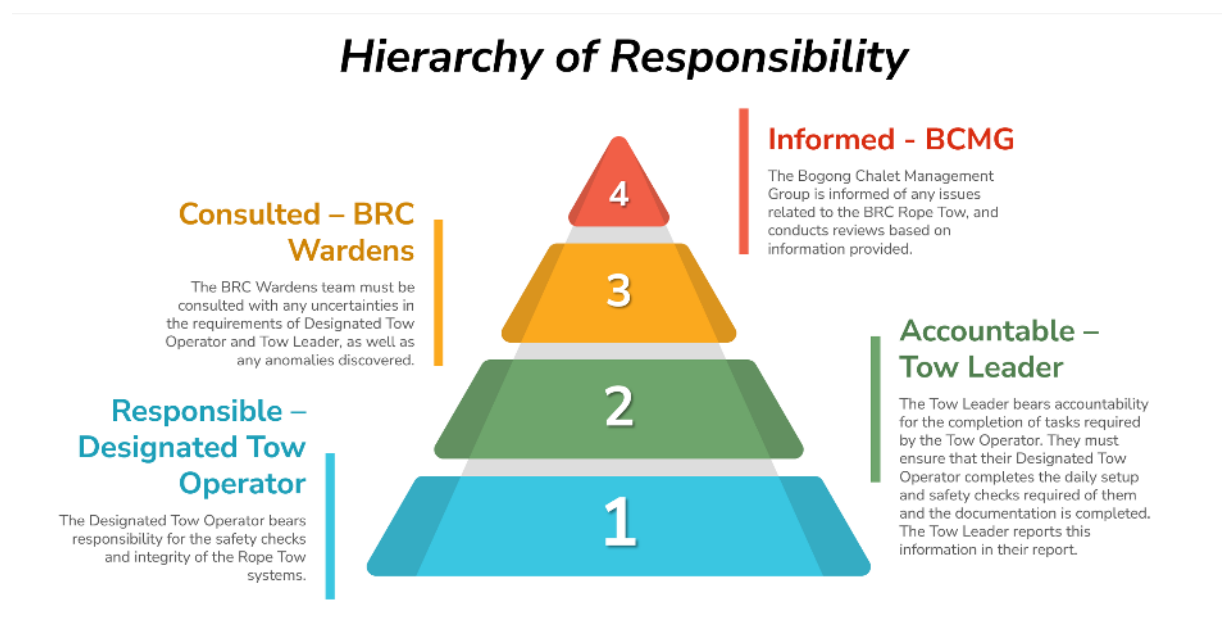
- How to safely ride the tow including mount and dismount and use of the attachment belt

- How to navigate the rope sheaves and other obstacles while riding the tow
- Where to mount and dismount
- The requirement to ski in control
- A description of the rope tow terrain including borders of the rope tow terrain, creek hazards, trees and designation of areas as suitable for beginner skiers, making reference to Terrain Map
- How to use the emergency stop system
- Safe storage of nutcracker while skiing to prevent injury in a fall
- Helmet policy
- The requirement for daily safety checks
- How to self-supervise trained users of the tow

The Tow Brief will preferably be conducted by the Tow Leader, but can be conducted by any Tow Operator. The Tow Leader is responsible for ensuring that this briefing is completed in its entirety with the whole party. This briefing should be conducted on the snow at the Road Loading Point, where participants can physically see the towline, sheaths, an emergency stop button and local terrain.

Prior to first operation of the rope tow on any winter party, a thorough safety check of the rope tow must be conducted. The safety check must include:

- For the first and last operation of the season: recorded observation of a full cycle of the rope to check for rope defects. This recording will be sent alongside the Tow Leader report.
- Simultaneous observation of the tow motor operation to check that the motor is operating within safe limits (temperatures, pressures, etc.)



BRC Rope Tow Operations utilise the above Hierarchy of Responsibility. Tow Leaders designate responsibility to Designated Tow Operators, who hold responsibility for safety

and integrity checks as well as operational requirements. Tow Leaders are then accountable in ensuring their Designated Tow Operator completes the tasks they are responsible for. The BRC Wardens team must be consulted by the Designated Tow Operator and Tow Leader when uncertainty exists. The BCMG must be informed of any issues in BRC Rope Tow systems, procedures and incidents, who then must review these points annually.

Instructions for starting and operating the tow are provided in the tow hut and in the folder under the phone in the chalet. The instructions include:

- How to safely start and stop the tow motor
- How to set up the unloading station including:
 - How to prepare the unloading area
 - Creating and testing the e-safety gate
 - Setting out signage
- How to set up the marshalling stations at the loading areas including signage
- How to check the safety stops prior to use including logging
- How to set the sheave height and rope tension
- Safe operating speed limits

All users must be informed that any operation of the tow outside of the rope tow instructions and guidelines is not allowed. Failure to comply must be reported as a near miss.

Prior to each daily use of the rope tow, the rope tow will be inspected to:

- Determine that the rope tow is rideable from the lowest used loading station to the highest used unloading station
- Determine that the loading and unloading areas are clear and safe for use
- Determine that the sheaves are set at a height for safe use of the tow (not more than 1.5m above compacted snow level and at a safe level for **ALL** participants).
- Ensure that the haul rope is removed from its overnight storage position
- Determine and report the general state of the snow (icy, firm, soft, slushy)
- Check and log the operability of the e-safety stops

When users are using the rope tow:

- The active loading station(s) will be attended in accordance with CSA Z98:2019 §13.5
- In addition, the active unloading station(s) will be attended.
- A Tow Supervisor must supervise the unloading and loading stations
- A Tow Supervisor or Tow Operator must supervise the loading of untrained users until the untrained users are deemed competent to load without supervision

- There must be a minimum of 4 users skiing if users are skiing fringe terrain or beyond marked bounds (marked in red or colourless on map)- in which case the buddy system applies. It can be run with lower numbers if skiing non-fringe terrain (marked in green and blue on map), and the buddy system does not apply.
- Users will use the chalet check out/check in whiteboard procedure

Logging

Daily tow operation shall be logged including:

- Inspection check list
- Safety stop checks
- Hours of operation
- Fuel

An operational checklist and logbook shall be provided in the tow hut for this purpose.

A rope inspection log shall be maintained as required by the standard.

Training

CSA Z98:2019

13.2.1 Management and other personnel responsible for operation shall be familiar with the applicable provisions of this standard

13.2.2. Passenger ropeways and passenger conveyors shall be operated by trained and competent persons

13.3.3 The owner or the owner's representative shall be responsible for supervising and training all personnel

At the completion of each winter party where the rope tow has been used, the Tow Leader must record all users of the rope tow and their competency (Tow Trained User, Tow Supervisor, Tow Operator). At the conclusion of winter each year, the BCMG shall review the competencies and elevate Trained Users to Supervisors (and Supervisors to Operators) as appropriate and recorded in the *BRC Rope Tow Competencies Database*.

Helmets

Current ski resort policy states that helmet use is a matter of personal or parental choice when not required by company or resort management policies. Compared to a ski resort, some of the risks at the BRC rope tow are reduced due to:

- No grooming of the surface means that the snow may not be as hard and compact nor as fast
- Under hard icy conditions, it is not enjoyable to use the rope tow and ski the terrain and thus the tow is seldom used under these conditions
- The rope tow has a relatively low occupancy rate leading to few skiers on the terrain at any one time and low probability and frequency of collisions
- While skiers can achieve high speeds sufficient to cause injury, in general, the variability of the snowpack means that speeds tend to be much lower than skiers at resorts

Despite the high level of use of the rope tow, minimal number of injuries and incidents have occurred.

For these reasons, encouraging users to wear helmets is currently deemed sufficient. This position will be reviewed at least once every three years to take account of changes to current best practice. Please see Bogong Chalet Helmet documentation.

Participants will be informed, during their briefing night, that helmets are encouraged for use on the Rope Tow to enable users to bring their own helmets if desired.

CURRENT (2026) GUIDELINES ARE THAT THE ROPE TOW IS NOT TO BE USED ON VENTURER WEEKS. Should this change, Venturer weeks may set a more compulsory helmet requirement. Where a parent or guardian has indicated that a youth member is required to wear a helmet, that youth member shall not be permitted to use the rope tow unless wearing a helmet.

Review

At the conclusion of each winter season, a review of the operation of the rope tow must be conducted and an action plan will be put in place for the following season. See *BRC Rope Tow End of Season Review* document.

Risk Management

See separate *Risk assessment – Rope Tow.xlsx* document.

- Rope tow activity is typically conducted using the chalet as a base for meals and to return to if cold, tired, injured or to change or replace clothing. Other than an immobilising incident (injury or gear failure), the contingency for any incident will be to return to the chalet. For immobilising incidents, the contingency will be to send for help using radios if carrying and/or by sending another rope tow user to the chalet to raise alarms and seek assistance.

- Active users of the rope tow are required to write their name on the chalet whiteboard and remove their name on return to the chalet.
- There will be a minimum of 4 active users of the rope tow when users are skiing fringe terrain or beyond marked bounds (marked in red or clear on the map).
 - Rope tow skiing within the coloured area defined by the terrain map does not require a trip intention form.
- All users are required to be present at the Tow Trained User Training Briefing to (re-)learn safety procedures, terrain boundaries, rope management etc. The rope tow itself is a fail-safe system, i.e. if anything occurs to the user during use of the rope tow (belt failure is the most likely), the default position is that the user detaches from the rope before any major incident or injury occurs.
- Detailed operation notes are provided and operating the rope tow outside of these boundaries will not be condoned.
- Rope tow users will be reminded to ski in control and to the conditions.
- Conditions will be reported from the operator of the rope tow to rope tow users.

Terrain hazards within the terrain map area include:

- Trees
- Rocks
- Bare patches
- Ice
- Creek crossings
- Steep slopes outside of a participants' competence
- Hidden obstacles including any of the above are managed by:
 - Encouraging participants to ski in control and within personal limits
 - Reporting observed obstacles and marking them with orange conduit
 - Avoiding the use of the rope tow in low visibility conditions
 - Avoiding the use of the rope tow in icy conditions

Reporting systems are in place to advise Party Leaders, Tow Leaders and by extension all designated Tow Operators of the level of competence of participants within the winter party. A Tow Briefing is conducted prior to first use of the tow on any given week in front of the entire winter party.

For these reasons, **ONLY REGISTERED WINTER PARTY PARTICIPANTS FOR THAT WEEK ARE TO USE THE ROPE TOW**. If non-registered persons insist on using the rope tow, the rope tow shall be shut down and the incident reported directly to the wardens, who will provide further instruction.

Emergency management

If a participant requires immediate medical attention, call 000.

Request assistance from the chalet if the emergency can be managed with additional people and/or equipment.

Contact the chalet if there is any emergency (either by radio or by sending personnel).

Consider whether to manage an injured or incapacitated person without moving, or transport back to the chalet.

Rescue equipment available at the chalet includes Akja rescue sled, snowshoes, roll up stretcher, blankets, sleeping bag, tarpaulin. The Akja presents its own risks and only those practised in the use of the Akja should do so.

If a person cannot walk back to the chalet, contact the chalet and arrange for them to bring the Akja rescue sled to transport the person back to the chalet if safe to do so. Careful consideration should be given to the competence of Akja users before the Akja is used to transport a participant up or down any slope. It is better to call for emergency services assistance than to risk additional or exacerbated incidents due to improper use of the Akja.

If emergency services are called, or a person requires immediate medical treatment, you must contact the chalet Warden Matt Anderson on [REDACTED] A Scouts Victoria incident report will need to be submitted within 48 hours of the end of the trip. Keep notes to assist with preparing this incident report. The Scouts Victoria Emergency Line 03 8543 9877 should also be notified.

Emergency numbers

Bogong Rover Chalet - [REDACTED]

Bogong Rover Chalet Warden - Matt Anderson [REDACTED]

Scouts Victoria Emergency Line 03 8543 9877

FOR ALL EMERGENCIES CALL 000